

From temporalism and contingentism to elitism

Handout for *Time and Modality* seminar

Cian Dorr

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1 The “roles” of times and worlds

- (A) Connections between ‘at t' ’/‘at w' ’ and other temporal/modal modifiers.
- F It will be the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some future instant, ϕ
 - P It has been the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some past instant, ϕ
 - G It will always be the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at every future instant, ϕ
 - H It has always been the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at every past instant, ϕ
 - A It is always the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at every instant, ϕ
 - S It is sometimes the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some instant, ϕ
 - $\diamond$ It is possible for it to be the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some possible world, ϕ
 - $\square$ It is necessarily the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at every possible world, ϕ
- (B) Relations between ‘at’ and truth-functional connectives:
- $\text{At} \wedge$ At i , (ϕ and ψ) $\leftrightarrow$ at i , ϕ and at i , ψ
 - $\text{At} \vee$ At i , (ϕ or ψ) $\leftrightarrow$ at i , ϕ or at i , ψ
 - $\text{At} \neg$ At i , it is not the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ it is not the case that at i , ϕ
- (C) The *before/after* relation among instants, and the *accessibility* relation among worlds:
- $\text{At} \text{-F}$ At t , it will be the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some instant t' after t , ϕ
 - $\text{At} \text{-P}$ At t , it has been the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some instant t' before t , ϕ
 - $\text{At} \text{-}\diamond$ At w , it is possible for it to be the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at some w' accessible from w , ϕ
 - $\text{At} \text{-}\square$ At w , it is necessarily the case that $\phi \leftrightarrow$ at every w' accessible from w , ϕ
- (D) The temporal and modal status of ‘at t' ’ and ‘at w' ’ facts:
- Permanence*: If at t , ϕ then it is always the case that at t , ϕ
 - Invariance*: If at w , ϕ then it is necessary that at w , ϕ

2 An argument from propositional temporalism to temporal elitism

Propositional temporalism: Some true proposition has been or will be untrue.

i is accurate $=_df$ All and only the true propositions are true at i .

- P1 If propositional temporalism is true, at most one instant is accurate.
- P2 If propositional temporalism is true, the present instant is accurate.
- P3 Accuracy is a pretty natural property.
- P4 The extension of any pretty natural property is a pretty natural class.
- P5 The unit classes of most instants are not even close to being pretty natural.
- C So, if propositional temporalism is true, the unit class of the present instant is much more natural than those of most instants.

Modal analogue: replace ‘instant’ with ‘world’, ‘present’ with ‘actualised’.

3 Discussion of premises

P1:

- Propositional temporalism clearly entails that not *all* instants are accurate. Suppose that p is true but sometimes not true; then [ROLE] there is some instant at which p is not true; so there is at least one inaccurate instant.
- Given that propositional temporalists should accept the inference from 'Sometimes ϕ ' to 'The proposition that ϕ is sometimes true', there is a pretty straightforward route to the claim that *almost all* instants are not accurate.
- An argument that at most one instant is accurate:
 - (i) No instant is *present* at any instant other than itself
 - (ii) Exactly one instant is present
 - (iii) So, every non-present instant is inaccurate (since the true proposition about which instant is present is not true at it).
- Justifying (i) in that argument:
 - a. Every instant is either before or after every instant other than itself
 - b. If t_1 is before t_2 , t_1 is past at t_2 [ROLE]
 - c. If t_1 is after t_2 , t_1 is future at t_2 [ROLE]
 - d. Necessarily, nothing is both past and present or both future and present
 - e. So at every instant, nothing is both past and present or both future and present
 - f. So at every instant, every other instant is non-present.

P2:

- Argument for P2:
 - (i) Every instant is accurate at itself.
 - (ii) Every instant is present at itself.
 - (iii) So, at every instant, there is an instant that is both present and accurate.
 - (iv) So it is always the case that there is an instant that is both present and accurate.
 - (v) So there is an instant that is both present and accurate.
- Justifying (i):
 - a. For every p : if p is true at t , then always, p is true at t [ROLE]
 - b. So for every p : p is true at t iff p is true at t at t [ROLE]
 - c. So for every p : at t (p is true iff p is true at t) [ROLE]
 - d. So at t (for every p , p is true iff p is true at t) (?)
 - e. So at t , t is accurate.

Lewisian naturalness-theoretic claims that favour P3:

- The more natural a property is, the easier it is to refer to or express.
- Sharing of natural properties makes for similarity; division by natural properties makes for dissimilarity.
- Everything supervenes on the perfectly natural properties.

(Brief discussion of P4 and P5.)

4 A challenge for deniers of P3 (or P4)

Give us enough of an alternative grip on how you are using ‘natural’, and why, to make it clear that you’re not just speaking in an eccentric way!

There are many these about naturalness that don’t involve instants at all but seem characteristic of the temporal elitist. E.g. many theses of the form

The class that now contains all and only *F* objects is much more natural than most of the classes that will contain or have contained all and only *F* objects.

I take it that temporal egalitarians trying to spell out a positive picture of how naturalness works will need to deny such claims. Plausibly, they will hold that truths about the naturalness of classes are permanent (although not all truths are permanent).

5 Non-factualism

Temporal non-factualism: temporary questions are non-factual. Modal non-factualism: contingent questions are non-factual.

Background history of metaethics:

- Emotivists (e.g. Ayer): Ethical sentences are not true or false; they do not express propositions, but rather perform the quite different linguistic function of expressing non-cognitive mental states.
- Quasi-realists (e.g. Blackburn): ‘The proposition that lying is always wrong is true’ has the same (attitude-expressing) semantic profile as ‘Lying is always wrong’; ‘Kantians believe that lying is always wrong’ has the same semantic profile as ‘Kantians disapprove of all cases of lying’, etc.
- Challenge of ‘creeping minimalism’ (e.g. Dreier): Isn’t the view just a piece of philosophy of mind, completely irrelevant to metaphysics?
- One reaction to this challenge (e.g. Fine): There is an important and intelligible metaphysical question about which realists and quasi-realists disagree. But we need high-powered, distinctive vocabulary to express this question. E.g.: while agreeing that ethical sentences express propositions that can be true or false and believed or disbelieved, we can still ask whether they express PROPOSITIONS that can be TRUE or FALSE and BELIEVED or DISBELIEVED. Or: while agreeing that lying is either wrong or not wrong, we can still ask whether lying is either FACTUALLY wrong or FACTUALLY not wrong. . . .
- (My queasy attitude about this.)

What does temporal/modal non-factualism have to do with temporal/modal egalitarianism? One possibility: we build it into the notion of a natural property that it must always be a factual question whether something instantiates a natural property or not. So only permanent/non-contingent properties are natural to any degree, so the natural class facts are permanent/non-contingent.

An alternative view (or is it?): Temporal (modal) elitism is TRUE; the unit class of the present instant (actual world) IS highly natural; but it is not factual that it is highly natural.

6 Relativism

Slogans that darken understanding:

‘Truth for propositions is relative to an *F*’

‘Propositions are true or false only relative to an F ’

‘We should relativise truth to F s’

What does ‘ G -ness is relative to an F ’ normally mean? (i) Something can be G relative to one F and not G relative to a different F . (ii) When we ask ‘Is this thing G ?’, the only questions we could be getting on to are questions about whether it is G relative to this or that F ; there is no further meaningful question that we could ask by asking ‘Is it G simpliciter?’; (iii) The relevant F when the predicate ‘ G ’ is used without explicitly mentioning an F is not always the same. Upshot: contextualism about the predicate ‘ G ’.

A possible but unattractive view: when we say ‘ p is true’, there is always some particular time t such that what we say is equivalent to the claim that p is true at t . There are temporal propositions, but sentences of the form ‘ p is true’ don’t express them.

Modern relativists don’t go for this: they allow for an ‘object-language’, ‘deflationary’ use of ‘true’. But then what does ‘truth is relative to an F ’ mean, other than ‘A proposition can be true relative to one F and not true relative to another F ’?

One reaction: we have to take an ‘absolutely’ or ‘objectively’ operator as primitive. The characteristic “temporal relativist” claim is that whenever it is absolutely/objectively the case that P , it is always the case that P .

- Obviously we can’t just *define* ‘absolutely P ’ as ‘at every time, P ’ if we want this to be non-trivial!
- The view seems essentially the same as the ‘non-factualist’ view discussed earlier, just with a different pronunciation of the primitive operator.